

## Element A: Presentation and Justification of the Problem

### Problem Statement and Details

#### 1) Who is involved in this problem?

The people involved in this problem are the people who want their Rabbits to have a tunnel that they will be able to go through. The people that want to see their rabbits all the time or want to be able to safely carry it around or for them to not get hurt with the metal are involved in this problem.

#### 2) What are they doing?

They are trying to make a design that is easy to clean, isn't very bulky and non-toxic for the rabbits. They are also trying to make it have soft edges, and make it easy to access the rabbits or just to be able to check up on how they are doing. They are also trying to make it where they want to carry it around in an easy way so they can put it in different places.

#### 3) What unique situations does the problem occur within, if any?

A situation could be when you're cleaning it you could get splinters from the wood or cut yourself from the metal. Whenever you have sharp edges you could also easily cut yourself or accidentally hurt the bunny when taking it out of the cage. The rabbit might not be able to be found because it is tucked away in the tunnel whenever it's sleeping so they won't be able to take it out to perform welfare checks or showing the animals to any visitors.

#### 4) What is the size of the issue?

The size of the issue could be big because if you get a bad enough cut like if you get a punctured wound that is extended into the deeper tissue layers. If the wound is bleeding severely you might have to call 911 or a local emergency number\*. Losing the bunny could be big if you can't be able to check its wellness and health.

5) Where is the problem happening?

This problem is happening at the edges and areas of the tunnel that aren't easily able to find the rabbit and even if you know where they are at it they might get hurt trying to get it. Whenever the rabbit walks in the tunnel it might get caught in the sharp edges without anyone noticing because they aren't there in the same room as them.

6) When does the problem occur?

Whenever they have to check up on the Rabbit or when they want to be able to move the actual build to another location. This also may happen whenever they aren't being careful with what they are doing.

7) Why does the problem happen?

The edges are super sharp so if you go to fast without thinking about it you could accidentally cut yourself or get yourself a splinter on the wood. This problem happens because of the way the tunnel is designed it wasn't really thought about if you would get cut or not.

8) How often does the problem happen?

The problem could happen pretty often because you have to be able to feed the bunny and be able to take the bunny out a lot to be able to clean and make sure it's healthy and has food and water to drink.

## Stakeholder Concerns and Connections

- 1) Veterinarians
- 2) Rabbit rescue organizations
- 3) Animal welfare advocates
- 4) House rabbit owners
- 5) Shelter professionals [\\*](#)

Veterinarians are primarily concerned with high rates of preventable illness in rabbits caused by poor diet (lack of hay leading to dental disease/GI stasis), inadequate husbandry, and lack of specialized, knowledgeable care [\\*](#)

Rabbit rescue organizations are deeply concerned by high abandonment rates, improper care, and the "disposable" perception of pet rabbits, which often leads to overcrowding in shelters. [\\*](#)

Animal welfare advocates are deeply concerned about the widespread neglect, abandonment, and misunderstanding of rabbits as pets, particularly around Easter. Key concerns include high abandonment rates, improper housing (small cages), lack of specialized care, and their unsuitability for small children.\*.

House rabbit owners commonly worry about their pets' delicate health—specifically gastrointestinal stasis, which requires immediate attention—along with destructive chewing behaviors, the need for specialized exotic vet care, and finding proper, hay-based diets. Other concerns include the high cost of care, the need for extensive bunny-proofing, their dislike of being picked up, and managing their sensitivity to environmental factors like heat and air fresheners.\*.

Shelter professionals face significant challenges with rabbit care, primarily concerning inadequate, small-cage housing that causes stress and health issues. Key concerns include high, seasonal abandonment rates, the need for specialized care/socialization, and the risks of diseases like RHDV2. They emphasize the need for large, species-appropriate enclosures and environmental enrichment.\*.

### **Problem Importance**

This problem is important because House Rabbit Owners need an easier way to check up on their bunnies to see if they are okay and make sure they can get the food that they need to live. Also another problem is that you can easily be cut by the wood of the tunnel and the metal in the inside of the tunnel and the rabbit might be able to be cut by it. These problems need to be solved now because it could create problems for the rabbits health and later on might not be in good health.

Data regarding rabbit injuries from cage sharp edges, often referred to in studies as "skin injuries," "wire wounds," or "sore hocks" caused by inappropriate flooring, indicates a significant welfare concern in industrial or improperly designed housing. Studies on caged rabbits (often in the meat industry) show that injuries and footpad problems are common, with incidence rates sometimes exceeding 25% for injuries, depending on the floor design, and up to 94% of rabbits being kept in cage systems, according to a 2017 EU report.\*.

Resources:

[Question 4](#)

[Stakeholders](#)

[Veterinarians Concerns](#)

[Rabbit Rescue Organizations Concerns](#)  
[Animal Welfare Advocates](#)  
[House Rabbit Owners](#)  
[Shelter Professionals Concerns](#) .  
[Data and Statistics](#)